

MULCH OPTIONS

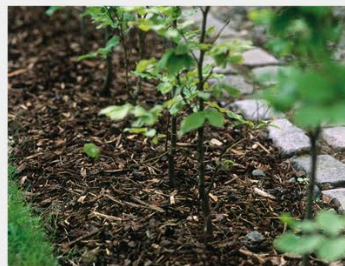
Mulches reduce weed growth and conserve water, which is why they should always be applied when the ground is moist. A gravel mulch helps to keep the leaves and stems of drought-loving plants dry, and prevents

them from rotting. As well as being functional, many mulches are also attractive, and produce a decorative surface for borders and containers. Recycled ground glass and dyed shells are colorful options.



Gravel

Gravel laid over landscape fabric creates a weed suppressant and a decorative foil for alpine and Mediterranean-style plantings. Plant through the fabric by cutting a cross and folding back the flaps. Apply the gravel on top after planting.



Bark chips

Available in different sizes, the smallest being the most attractive, bark breaks down slowly and makes a good weed suppressor. It also helps to conserve soil moisture, but does not supply many nutrients. Top off worn areas annually.



Garden compost

Rotted compost and manure lock moisture into the soil and help to suppress weed growth. As the mulch breaks down it also releases plant foods and improves the structure of the soil.



Leaf mold

Although low in nutrients, rotted leaves help to improve the soil structure and trap moisture in. They are ideal for woodland and shade-loving plants, many of which would be mulched by leaves in their natural habitats.

as liquids, powders that you dilute in water, or granules. Organic fertilizers include pelleted chicken manure; fish, blood and bonemeal; liquid seaweed fertilizer; and homemade plant feeds, such as the diluted liquor from a wormery or fertilizers made from soaking comfrey leaves. Inorganic fertilizers include potassium sulfate and granular rose fertilizers.

Fertilizers are grouped according to the quantities of N, P, and K they contain. For example, a balanced fertilizer for general use, contains equal quantities of each primary nutrient, while a fertilizer for lawns has a higher concentration of nitrogen, and those for fruit bushes are rich in potassium.

Apply an all-purpose granular fertilizer to the soil when planting, and spread around plants in spring. Containers, baskets, and some bedding annuals may need a regular liquid feed during the growing season, or apply a controlled-release granular fertilizer when planting. Remember to follow the manufacturer's directions carefully.

Mulching

Mulches are materials that are spread on the soil surface, usually around plants. Some mulches serve a practical purpose—feeding the soil, suppressing weeds, retaining moisture, or insulating roots in winter—while others are primarily decorative. Decorative mulches include crushed glass or shells, and slate chips.

Mulches are applied at different times of the year, depending on their purpose and

the plants' needs. For example, bark chips are spread over the soil surface after planting to suppress weeds, but may take nutrients from the soil as they decompose, so apply a nitrogen-rich fertilizer to compensate for this loss. Organic matter, such as farmyard manure or garden compost, helps to retain soil moisture while also fertilizing the ground. It must be laid over moist soil, either in spring (following fall and winter rains) or after watering. Apply organic mulches in a thick layer about 4in (10cm) deep, and replenish them annually as worms and soil micro-organisms will break them down throughout the year.

Composting

Disposing of your organic kitchen waste and plant prunings by composting creates an excellent eco-friendly soil improver. There is a wide range of bins available, including standard plastic composters that hold plenty of waste, and more decorative types, such as wooden models that resemble beehives.

To produce good compost, you will need the right mix of ingredients. Too much soft green material, such as grass clippings and vegetable peelings, turns the heap into a slimy mess. On the other hand, if you include too much dry woody material, such as prunings, the heap will rot down too slowly. Aim for an equal measure of green and dry ingredients and add them in layers. A good airflow is also essential to the composting process, so turn over the contents regularly.

MAKING LEAF MOLD

Leaf mold is one of the finest soil conditioners, and makes good use of fallen autumn leaves. It is very quick and easy to make, but takes at least a year to rot down and be ready for use in the garden.



1 Rake up the leaves

In fall, rake up the leaves in your garden and place them in large plastic garbage bags. If you chop them up first with a garden spade, they will decompose faster.



2 Water, tie and leave

When the bags are half full, sprinkle the leaves with water. Continue to add leaves and water again when full. Tie the bag and make a few holes with a fork to let in some air. After a year or two, the leaf mold will be ready.